

How do I navigate AI use as a very helpful tool when it has such a negative environmental impact?

Posted by u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 0 points • 15 comments

I am a college student and in the past 2 years I've started to use AI pretty consistently. I'm a stem major at a rigorous research based college. The coursework is intense so AI has been really helpful. I don't have it write for me. I don't have it do my assignments. But I often ask it to help me breakdown and walk-through concepts or explain how to do problems I don't understand. I have learning disabilities so it just takes me longer to grasp concepts, and I need to be able to see them in different ways and "talk" through them this is where AI really helps. I don't think I'm over dependent on it because I do well on my exams and I am building my own understanding that I can apply to the real world and my assignments. But I don't know, I feel overall AI has genuinely been a great learning tool. I am aware of the cognitive effects of AI use so I really don't use it to solve my problems or do my work. I use it kind of just as a tutor who can explain things that are confusing in more detail. It's convenient to be able to send a question to ChatGPT and it give a targeted response and full breakdown of the specific concept instead of having to dig through multiple sources or watch 30 minute videos only to have a irrelevant answer to the question. And maybe that is a problem I don't know.

I try to be really involved in the world and do my part to reduce my environmental impact. I try to support businesses with good morals. I'm really conscious of the impact I can make even as just one individual and I really try to be aware of how to be a good person and support the right things.

Because of this my AI use has now become a serious moral dilemma because on one hand I feel that I'm using it appropriately and it's really helping me. However, I can't ignore the environmental impact it's making and the communities that are being so heavily affected by these data centers and the fact that I'm supporting corrupt billionaires!

So how do I navigate it as a really helpful tool for my college career with the moral implications that come with its use. HELP.

Comments

u/pillowsoftgirl • 2 points • 2026-02-24 18:53 UTC

I think you're putting a lot on your own shoulders here honestly. The environmental cost of one student using AI as a tutor is tiny compared to like streaming video all night or commuting an hour to campus, and you're clearly

using it thoughtfully not to cheat. If it's genuinely helping you learn and manage a disability, that matters too, you're not a villain for trying to get through orgo at 11pm.

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 21:52 UTC

Thank you this is well said and I really appreciate this. This is exactly why this situation feels so difficult because I am one student genuinely just trying to learn and do well yet if everyone in the world says that then the problems continue. Why can't the developers of AI just be responsible and make the service ethical and environmentally, friendly then there would be no issues. АННННННН.

u/ZookeepergameLow8520 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 17:37 UTC

Потратить 5 грамм CO2 на один точный ответ ИИ часто гораздо экологичнее, чем сжечь 50 грамм CO2, блуждая по интернету в течение часа и загружая сотни ненужных серверов.

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 17:54 UTC

I didn't think about it that way. Why is it so hard to try to do the right thing while also helping yourself succeed.

u/ZookeepergameLow8520 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:01 UTC

Вы поступаете правильно используя ИИ в качестве репетитора. Вы тратите меньше ресурсов физических и вы экономите свое время. Вы не можете просто вернуться в каменный век, взять палку и начать царапать на стенах, чтобы решить пример - к примеру, сложить два числа. Вы посчитаете на калькуляторе, в телефоне, ноутбуке. Из двух зол нужно выбрать наименьшее. В данном случае - это использование ИИ для обучающих целей.

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:12 UTC

Thank you I appreciate this feedback. I agree the world is changing one of my professors actually told me "If you have questions ask AI it will probably teach it better than me" like what! It's so hard to know what's right because AI is a tool and I'm trying to use the tools I have in the right way to aid my success but yes it's environmentally damaging so it's a very controversial problem.

u/ZookeepergameLow8520 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:32 UTC

Какое бы решение вы не приняли, надеюсь, вы найдете гармонию и сохраните душевное равновесие. Нельзя делать что-то и терзать себя муками, что вы вредите кому-то или поступаете плохо.

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:35 UTC

Thank you! I really appreciate your perspectives!

u/ZookeepergameLow8520
• 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:39 UTC

И вам спасибо.
Я понимаю
ваши
переживания.

u/setophagacurculio • 1 points • 2026-02-24 17:20 UTC

just don't use it. you have professors you can visit during office hours who would be eager to take the time to walk you through concepts and would be so happy that someone is taking a genuine interest in their course. you have peers, subject tutors, and even forums (including reddit!) to ask questions to real human beings who know way more than AI ever could. people have gotten through college and life before generative AI and you

can do it too. just stick to your morals, and you'll learn so much more by hearing it from real humans, and you'll connect with people along the way. clearly you understand how terrible it is for the environment, so why contradict that understanding by continuing to engage in something you know is immoral?

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 17:52 UTC

You are totally right there's so many great resources on campus. My problem is I'm a non traditional student I live an hour from campus so I commute and I have family and work obligations that make it so hard to go to office hours. But I do try I have a tutor group it's just so hard when those resources aren't available during the weird times I'm doing my schoolwork. But I agree this is a really good alternative.

u/setophagacurculio • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:12 UTC

i understand that, you can also email professors and set up a time that works for you if their OHs are at weird times. you could even reach out to any professor in your department even if you don't take their class and they'll be more than happy to meet with you, if your professors aren't available. i'm glad you have a tutor group too, and there are probably students in your classes in similar situations who would like to meet and work together. and outside of that, there are so many videos online that explain concepts as well as stack exchange sites where you can find answers on your own time. i'm glad you're looking into alternatives, please stay strong in your convictions and don't cave to AI and the billionaire class.

u/Embarrassed-Tip8607 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 18:20 UTC

That's a good point I'm sure other people are struggling with this it's really hard because a lot of classes and professors are even leaning into and encouraging AI use. Maybe I need to start an avoid AI group on my campus so others with this problem can get together and like you said focus on human to human learning. It's just so hard when there never seems to be enough time in the day.

u/setophagacurculio • 1 points • 2026-02-24 20:01 UTC

that would be great, i'm sure there would be people that would love to join! and it's definitely hard, but doing the right thing is often hard but so so worth it

u/thekaz • 1 points • 2026-02-24 17:10 UTC

Maybe use AI as a last resort for understanding and instead do web searches on the topic first. Depending on the material, there may be videos online that do an even better job teaching the concepts. Then, if all else fails, go to AI.